

Familiar pattern

The Department of Telecom has issued a draft National Telecom Policy (NTP) 2025 at a time when digital connectivity is increasingly becoming the **backbone** of economic growth, social development, and national security. The **proposed** policy presents a **sweeping** and **ambitious** vision: **universal** broadband, 6G leadership, **ubiquitous** fibre, digital **inclusion**, and a future-ready regulatory **framework**.

On paper, the **intent** is **admirable**. But **scratch beneath the surface**, and a familiar pattern begins to **emerge**: **lofty** goals without clear **accountability**, targets recycled from previous policies, and little in the way of honest **assessment** of past performance. The most **glaring omission** in NTP 2025 **is** its failure to audit the performance of its **predecessor**, the National Digital Communications Policy (NDCP) 2018. That policy had its own set of **grand** promises: providing broadband access to all, 10 million public Wi-Fi hotspots, and 10 Gbps fixed broadband **infrastructure** to all gram panchayats. **Most** of these goals **have** not fully **materialised**. Take, **for instance**, the goal of achieving fibre connectivity in villages. The draft NTP 2025 once again aims to connect all gram panchayats with fibre. But this is not a new programme — it is a **carryover** from the BharatNet project, which has been **in the works** since 2011. Despite several relaunches, **Phase II** of BharatNet **remains** incomplete.

The **persistence** of the same **pain points suggests** not a failure of vision, but a failure of **execution** and **enforcement**, an issue the new policy does not **address**. **Indeed**, the absence of year-wise milestones, or binding **obligations** makes the draft read more like a vision document than an action plan. It **articulates** what needs to be done but not how it will be done, who will do it, or by when. Without such clarity, it risks becoming yet another policy that sets high expectations only to leave implementation to the **vagaries** of **bureaucracy**. **The lack** of an independent, institutional **mechanism** to **monitor** progress **is** equally troubling.

All this is, however, not to say the policy **lacks** merit. Its **recognition** of **emerging** areas like quantum communication, AI, and **edge computing is** welcome. The **push** for developing India's semiconductor and device manufacturing **ecosystem is** timely. But these positives will translate into **outcomes** only if the government **acknowledges** and addresses **the elephant in the room**: that previous policies have failed to deliver completely, and a repeat performance is unacceptable. The policy also **sidesteps** a **critical** concern for telecom users: the **emergence** of a **duopoly**, as two of the four **existing** operators continue to struggle. The timing also **raises questions**, with the Telecommunications Act, 2023, having **come into force** just last year, and some of its **provisions overlapping** with those in the draft NTP 2025, the **need** for a new policy document itself **appears somewhat redundant**. **[Practice Exercise]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Backbone** (noun) – foundation, pillar, support, spine, mainstay आधार
2. **Proposed** (adjective) – suggested, recommended, put forward, presented, advanced प्रस्तावित
3. **Sweeping** (adjective) – extensive, wide-ranging, comprehensive, broad, all-embracing व्यापक
4. **Ambitious** (adjective) – aspiring, enterprising, determined, driven, bold महत्त्वाकांक्षी
5. **Universal** (adjective) – global, widespread, all-encompassing, omnipresent, common सार्वभौमिक
6. **Ubiquitous** (adjective) – omnipresent, pervasive, widespread, universal, ever-present सर्वव्यापी
7. **Inclusion** (noun) – integration, incorporation, involvement, acceptance, amalgamation समावेशन
8. **Framework** (noun) – structure, outline, system, skeleton, scheme ढांचा
9. **Intent** (noun) – purpose, aim, objective, goal, determination इरादा
10. **Admirable** (adjective) – commendable, praiseworthy, laudable, worthy, excellent सराहनीय
11. **Scratch beneath the surface** (phrase) – to look further than what is obvious.
12. **Emerge** (verb) – arise, surface, develop, appear, unfold उभरना
13. **Lofty** (adjective) – grand, noble, high-minded, elevated, ambitious ऊँचे
14. **Accountability** (noun) – responsibility, liability, answerability, transparency, obligation जवाबदेही
15. **Assessment** (noun) – evaluation, appraisal, analysis, estimation, examination मूल्यांकन
16. **Glaring** (adjective) – obvious, conspicuous, blatant, evident, flagrant स्पष्ट
17. **Omission** (noun) – exclusion, oversight, lapse, neglect, deletion चूक
18. **Predecessor** (noun) – forerunner, precursor, antecedent, ancestor, former पूर्ववर्ती
19. **Grand** (adjective) – magnificent, majestic, splendid, noble, ambitious भव्य
20. **Infrastructure** (noun) – framework, foundation, system, base, facilities आधारभूत संरचना
21. **Materialise** (verb) – happen, occur, transpire, realise, unfold मूर्त रूप लेना

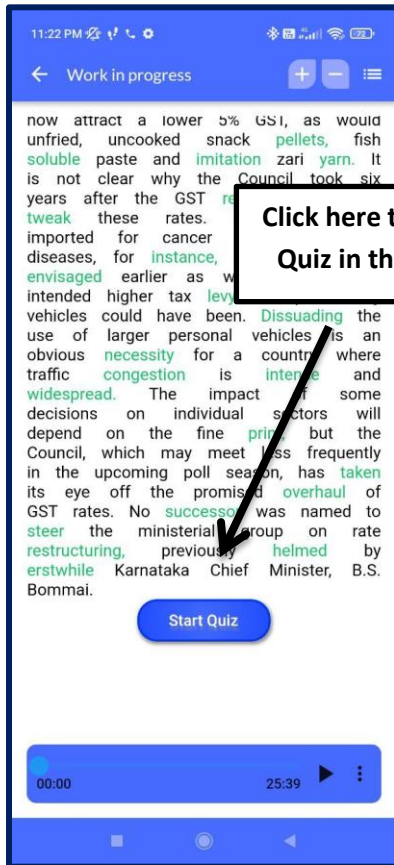
22. **For instance** (phrase) – for example, such as, to illustrate, namely, like उदाहरण के लिए
23. **Carryover** (noun) – continuation, extension, rollover, leftover, remnant अवशेष
24. **Be in the works** (phrase) – underway, in progress, in development, being planned, in motion प्रक्रिया में होना
25. **Persistence** (noun) – perseverance, tenacity, endurance, determination, continuity दृढ़ता
26. **Pain points** (phrase) – difficulties, issues, challenges, obstacles, problems समस्याएँ
27. **Execution** (noun) – implementation, carrying out, performance, accomplishment, enforcement कार्यान्वय
28. **Enforcement** (noun) – implementation, imposition, application, execution, reinforcement प्रवर्तन
29. **Address** (verb) – deal with, resolve, tackle, confront, approach समाधान करना
30. **Indeed** (adverb) – truly, certainly, undoubtedly, actually, in fact वास्तव में
31. **Obligation** (noun) – duty, responsibility, commitment, requirement, liability दायित्व
32. **Articulate** (verb) – express, communicate, convey, state, voice व्यक्त करना
33. **Vagary** (noun) – whim, impulse, unpredictability, caprice, fluctuation अनिश्चितताएँ
34. **Bureaucracy** (noun) – administration, officialdom, red tape, civil service, government नौकरशाही
35. **Mechanism** (noun) – system, process, structure, method, procedure प्रणाली
36. **Monitor** (verb) – observe, track, supervise, oversee, assess निगरानी रखना
37. **Lack** (verb) – be without, miss, need, want, fall short कमी होना
38. **Emerging** (adjective) – developing, rising, upcoming, nascent, budding उभरते हुए
39. **Edge computing** (noun) – a distributed computing model that brings computation and data storage closer to the sources of data.
40. **Push** (noun) – drive, initiative, thrust, campaign, effort प्रयास
41. **Ecosystem** (noun) – environment, system, network, domain, structure पारिस्थितिकी तंत्र
42. **Timely** (adjective) – opportune, prompt, well-timed, appropriate, suitable समय पर
43. **Outcome** (noun) – result, consequence, effect, output, aftermath परिणाम

44. **Acknowledge** (verb) – admit, accept, recognize, concede, appreciate स्वीकार करना
45. **The elephant in the room** (phrase) – a major problem or controversial issue which is obviously present but is avoided as a subject for discussion. टाल दिया गया बड़ा मुद्दा
46. **Sidestep** (verb) – avoid, evade, dodge, bypass, skirt टालना
47. **Critical** (adjective) – crucial, vital, essential, important, pivotal महत्वपूर्ण
48. **Emergence** (noun) – rise, appearance, development, evolution, inception उभरना
49. **Duopoly** (noun) – a situation in which two suppliers dominate the market for a commodity or service. द्वैधाधिकार
50. **Existing** (adjective) – current, present, prevailing, actual, available मौजूदा
51. **Raise question** (phrase) – provoke doubt, challenge, query, question, highlight सवाल उठाना
52. **Come into force** (phrase) – become effective, start operating, be enacted, take effect, apply लागू होना
53. **Provision** (noun) – clause, condition, requirement, term, stipulation प्रावधान
54. **Overlap** (verb) – intersect, coincide, overlie, extend over, encroach अतिव्याप्त होना
55. **Somewhat** (adverb) – slightly, rather, moderately, to some extent, fairly कुछ हद तक
56. **Redundant** (adjective) – unnecessary, superfluous, excessive, unneeded, surplus अनावश्यक

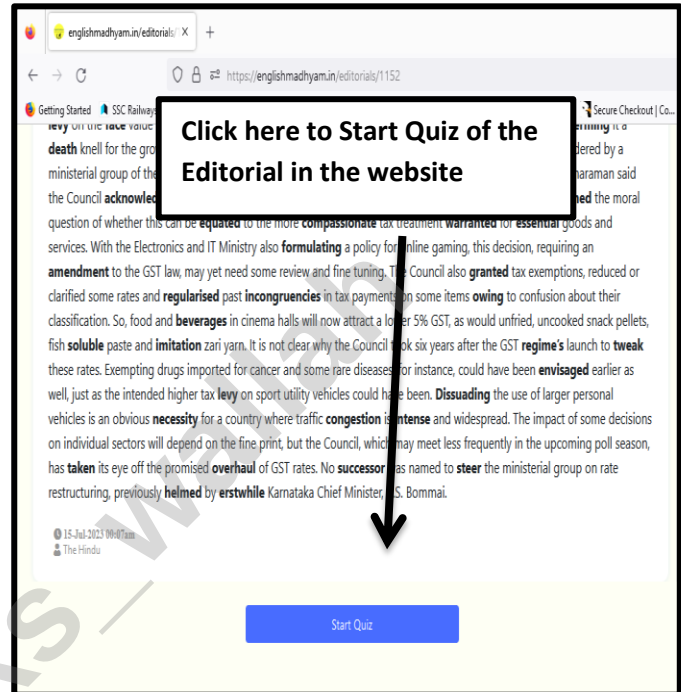
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Draft NTP 2025 Issued** – The Department of Telecom has released a draft National Telecom Policy 2025 amid growing reliance on digital infrastructure.
2. **Ambitious Vision Outlined** – The policy promises universal broadband, 6G leadership, digital inclusion, and a future-ready regulatory system.
3. **Intent vs. Reality** – While the goals are commendable, the document lacks clear mechanisms for accountability and execution.
4. **Recycled Promises** – Many targets are repetitions from earlier policies, particularly the National Digital Communications Policy (NDCP) 2018.
5. **No Audit of Past Policy** – NTP 2025 fails to assess the performance and shortcomings of NDCCP 2018, which remains largely unfulfilled.
6. **Unmet Goals** – Key promises from NDCCP 2018—like 10 million public Wi-Fi hotspots and broadband in every village—were not achieved.
7. **BharatNet Incompletion** – The goal to connect all gram panchayats with fibre is a recycled objective from the long-delayed BharatNet project started in 2011.
8. **Execution Failure** – The repeated failures point to issues in execution and enforcement, not in vision or ambition.
9. **No Concrete Action Plan** – The draft lacks year-wise targets, timelines, or accountability frameworks, making it more of a vision document.
10. **Bureaucratic Vagueness** – Without implementation details, it risks falling prey to bureaucratic delays and inefficiencies.
11. **Lack of Monitoring** – The absence of an independent body to monitor and evaluate progress is a major weakness.
12. **Recognition of Emerging Tech** – The policy rightly emphasizes areas like quantum communication, AI, edge computing, and semiconductor manufacturing.
13. **Execution is Key** – These futuristic goals will only be achieved if past failures are acknowledged and avoided.
14. **Telecom Duopoly Ignored** – The draft sidesteps concerns over market concentration, as two of four telecom players are struggling.
15. **Questionable Timing** – With the Telecommunications Act, 2023 recently enacted (with overlapping provisions), the need for a new policy document is questionable.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



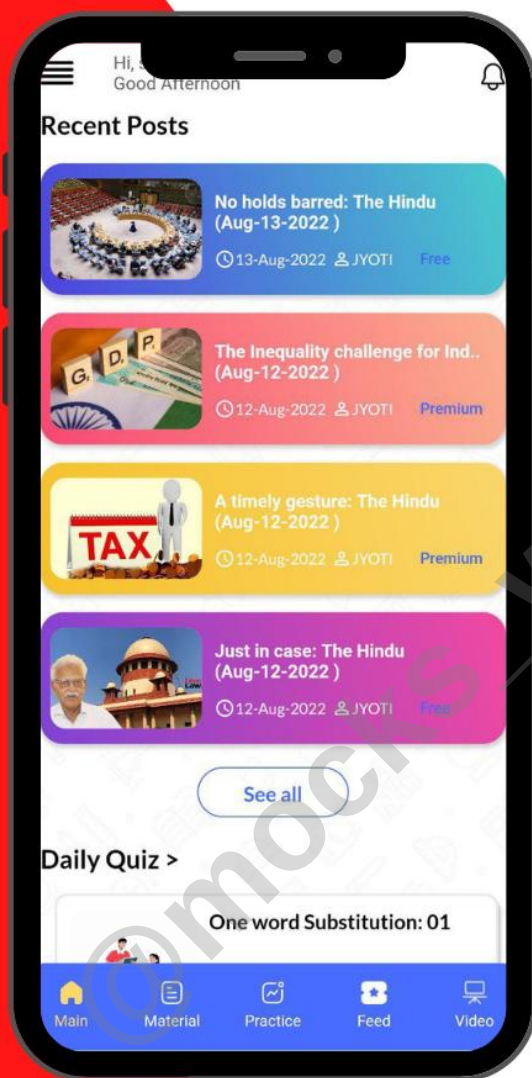
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